they tried to restrain the padishah ‘with stratagem’.[51] Only Bhagwant Das showed any kind of appetite for the venture, discerning three good omens on the way to Ahmedabad: it was a good sign, he said, that Akbar’s horse stopped for a moment along the way; that the wind was blowing in the enemy’s face; and that flocks of kites and ravens flew alongside Akbar’s troops – anticipating a feast of his dead foes.

Whatever their misgivings, when Akbar charged into the Sabarmati’s waters, his men were bound to follow. Across the river, Mirza Muhammad Husain’s red banners came into view and the padishah gave his troops a quick pep talk: ‘Today the measure of [the Mirza’s] worthless mettle will be taken.’[52] Akbar was favoured by God. So what if they were few in number? They would stay together, form a ‘fist’ to smash the Mirza’s ranks, lay the foe flat on the ground –

Allah-u-Akbar! Ya Mu’in!

But the fist came loose immediately.

The Mirza’s first salvo was to hurl firecrackers at the advancing corps. One burst before an elephant and it ran amok. The visor of Akbar’s helmet had broken as he crossed the Sabarmati and he had made a good omen out of it, declaring that now ‘our field of vision is open for the arrival of good news’.[53] What he saw, instead, was his men scattered wide.

‘Standing alone in the battlefield, the emperor called for warriors . . .’[54] – only two men heard him. Some others he could see fighting for their lives. A devil-may-care Kachhwaha who’d come to battle without armour died in front of the padishah’s eyes; another soldier fell wounded from his horse. Maldeo’s grandson Karan, clad in Rupsi’s jealously guarded breastplate, was fighting heroically.

An enemy soldier hit Akbar’s horse on the head with his sword. Akbar, steadying the animal by pulling at his mane with one hand, flung a spear with the other. It struck his foe but broke as Akbar was pulling it out; the soldier fled. Another took his place and slashed at Akbar’s thigh; a third hurled his blade at him.

As Akbar lost sight of his men, so they began to wonder about him. One of them, Saif Khan, was calling for him, ‘Ajmeri! Ajmeri!’[55] – was it an affectionate nickname or a code to disguise the padishah’s identity? It was this very Saif who had mourned having missed the ‘manhood-testing’ at